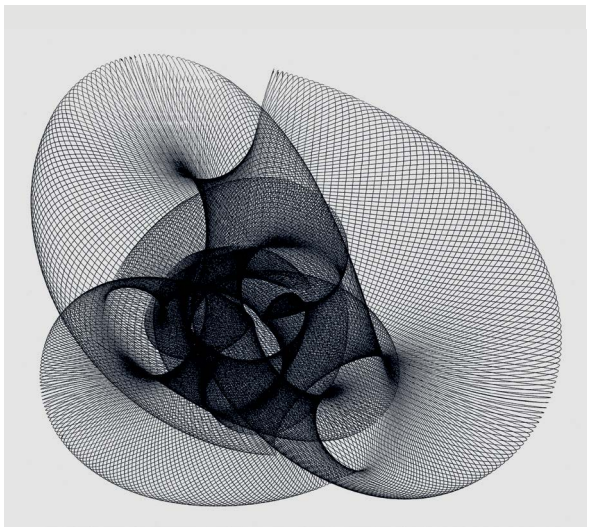
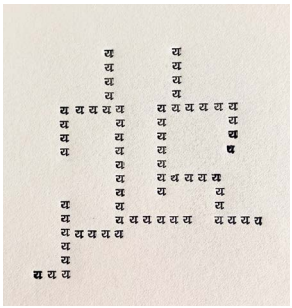
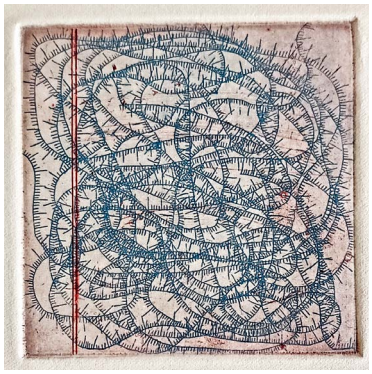
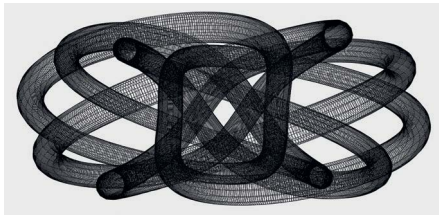








**ON DISPLAY** (Clockwise from the right) Primers from Poonam Jain's Practice Book series, Yogesh Barve's *Figure of Line–Torus Knot in Ortho*; Jain's *Year 66 Devanagari*; and Barve's *Figure of Line–Stardust*

EXHIBITION

# *Subversive* IN SUBURBIA

A MONTH-LONG SHOW AT ART AND CHARLIE, MUMBAI, SHOWCASING THE WORKS OF **POONAM JAIN** AND **YOGESH BARVE** POSES SEVERAL QUESTIONS TO THE VIEWER

One visionary curator plus two talented artists with subversive tendencies who've known each other for over a decade equals one extraordinary exhibition that asks *Three Questions At Once* (like its title), if not several more! The show by Poonam Jain and Yogesh Barve will be on between April 26 and May 25, at Art and Charlie in Mumbai's hip suburb of Bandra.

Curator Zeenat Nagree tells us how, at the core of the exhibition, is the idea that in whatever we create in our lives, and even in our daily activities, we carry certain questions with us. These questions even question how we engage with the world. While Jain's take is more of an examination of the past and its fast-fading relevance in the present, Barve's gaze is towards the future and whether or not we should hop on to the trajectory of technology. So different in concept and creation and yet so complementary as a theme.

This is an exhibition where you can leave all rules at the door. Nagree explains how this plays out, with her curatorial text printed on two decks of cards, one for each artist. The decks feature text on artworks but also cheeky instructions on how one can engage with the artworks. She says, "I want[ed] to use this to challenge how an exhibition is viewed. Even if people do not enact the instructions, the ideas are inserted in their minds. For example, what if you read the letters on Poonam's prints out loud? What if you tried to count the lines on one of Yogesh's drawings?"

At the core of the exhibition, is the idea that in whatever we create in our lives, and even in our daily activities, we carry certain questions with us

Expect drawings, letterpress prints, etchings, a video, and an interactive installation, and singer and actor Suman Sridhar reading Jain's letterpress prints of Devanagari letters as scores on opening night. The ground floor of the space is filled with kilos and kilos of the small circles produced when a set of papers is punched for spiral binding. "The audience will have to wade through this paper as if they are on a beach. Our usual instinct is to not touch paper with our feet, but this breaks that rule. We are confronted with residues of the kind of archiving activity that happens around us every day. The work addresses what is left out, what falls through the holes," says Nagree. The space also has an LCD screen on which Barve's video *Global III* plays. The video isn't visible to the naked eye as the screen's polariser film has been taken off and the video can only be seen through polarised glasses. Apparently, this strategy came from concerns with passive engagement.

Whatever way you interpret the diverse work, one thing is for sure, the show gives you a fresh feel of freedom and unpacks some food for thought too. ■

**–Priya Pathiyan**